The Chalky White Substance

By Tennessee Williams

__LUKE__ about twenty years of age, sits with an air of perplexed and anxious waiting. Upstage and to the left of him is seated MARK about eight years older, watching him with an enigmatic fixity of expression. After some moments __MARK__ rises and slides stealthily off{ his upstage perch. __LUKE__ removes from a pocket a small metal bottle containing water and a cloth which he dampens and with which he carefully and gently cleans his face .No sooner has he returned the bottle and cloth into the pocket than __MARK__ appears silently behind him and stoops to clasp his large, powerful hands over __LUKE__'s eyes.

MARK: Whooooo!

LUKE: YOU! -You can disguise your voice but not your hands. What makes you so late?

MARK: Boys are inquisitive, aren't they? What, why? I wasn't late. If you'd turned around, you'd have seen me sitting back there on that boulder behind you.

LUKE: Why?

MARK: I thought to myself, "It could be the last time I'll observe him, sitting here, waiting for me?"

LUKE: You're planning to go away? Somewhere? Without me?

MARK: Make a departure? From you? From this precipice over the Arroyo Seco, this desolation, so beautiful through the continual screen provided by the-chalky white substance? No, I'm making no departure. But how do I know that you're not?

LUKE: A secret departure? One I'd not mentioned to you?

MARK: Don't you know departures can be made without warning? You don't say you're going, you don't even know you're going, then *(Snaps his fingers.)* you're gone. Life's full of sudden departures; what a pity death isn't. *(Mark removes his hands from the youth's eyes.)*

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: A century or two after our time -- an almost equal time after the great thermonuclear war, a wind rises and falls, a wind that constantly blows about an earth as shriveled and desiccated as a terminally sick being.

ACTOR 2: Many picture the future of our Earth to be technologically advanced; however, Williams describes a desolate, war torn, and almost uninhabitable Earth; where women have failed to thrive. And the men battle daily for their very existence in the midst of . . .

TOGETHER: The Chalky White Substance by Tennessee Williams

MARK: Don't pull that cowl over your face.

LUKE: It protects my eyes from the dust always blowing, blowing constantly-from where?

MARK: The shrinking earth's a desert and barren mountains. In our part of it, the vicinity here, most of the chalky white stuff is provided by the Arroyo Seco, down there. I've heard that once, a few hundred years ago, there was a river in it-there's nothing drier and dustier than an arroyo in which there was once a river that's now dried up. *(The youth lowers the cowl over his head; Mark draws it back up.)*

LUKE: I thought you admired my eyes for being so clear, not inflamed?

MARK: This evening let me have a long look at your face, memorize it, as if I might never be going to see it again.

LUKE: You said you weren't going away, and I told you I wasn't, either. I still don't understand why you kept me waiting here while you were right back there all that time.

MARK: You learn a great deal about someone you care for by observing him without him knowing you are. You notice whether he waits indifferently, or with increasing concern as it gets later, oh, you learn many things you'd never know otherwise.

LUKE: What did you observe you didn't already know?

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MARK: More and more tension in you as the sky started to fade.

LUKE: You know I'm afraid of the dark when I'm alone at night. If it had gotten a bit darker, I would have started home and missed our meeting.

MARK: Fear, that's a bad thing to feel.

LUKE: A natural thing to feel. Now that women are so much fewer than men, there are bands of nomads that will seize a boy after dark and . . .

MARK: I know. Ravage him. And when their lusts are satiated, they leave no witness, just the lifeless body. -Lean back. *(Luke leans into his embrace.)* It always amazes me, the smoothness of your skin under the robe, not granulated at all by the chalky white substance.

LUKE: I know you like the touch of smooth skin, so I keep mine smooth for your pleasure.

MARK: How do you do that?

LUKE: Before I go to meet you here, I bathe myself and then immediately I put on my robe.

MARK: You bathe once a day before you come here to meet me, not just at night, as we're ordered to do?

LUKE: I bathe twice, once for you and again at night, Mark.

MARK: Bathe twice? Did you say twice.? But that would mean that you disregard the water restrictions as if they didn't exist. -You know, this confirms my suspicions that you have another protector, one in a high position in the regime, you little-cheater, yes, you get by with violating the restrictions because you give yourself at night to someone of great power among the

LUKE: I've never had more than one protector at a time. That one protector now is you.

MARK: Before me, you had others.

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LUKE: They were necessary. I hardly remember my parents. I'll tell you something that'll amuse you. On the wall at my place I have a colored picture of the lady that was called the Madonna.

MARK: Those old mythological pictures are a rarity now and could be sold to the center for special privileges, you know.

LUKE: I'd rather keep the picture on my wall.

MARK: What were you going to tell me that will amuse me? Something about the picture of the Madonna?

LUKE: Once I had a protector. When I woke up one morning, he was standing there staring at the picture. He said, "Is this your mother?"

MARK: Thought that the Madonna was your mother. . .

LUKE: The funny thing is that I said, 'Yes, that is, that was my mother." Women were a comfort. Why are they disappearing? Do they succumb more quickly to the chalk all about us now?

MARK: The earth's not able to support its shrinking population. There's little food, and even less water. I've heard that a man will use a woman awhile, and then, when she's no longer desirable to him, not as she was before, he's likely to destroy her. You see, Luke, the battle between people that happened so long ago that it's barely recorded, I understand that it had a brutalizing effect. Do you understand me?

LUKE: Brutalizing?

MARK: Opposite effect from the care of a Madonna.

LUKE: So that now we have only each other.

MARK: Have I told you that I have a woman at home?

LUKE: A mother? A Madonna? *(Mark laughs harshly.)*

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MARK: No, what remains of a girl, the remnant of her, used too much, not able now to excite me nor even to-serve. . . only to stagger about, looking more and more frightened. I suspect she knows.

LUKE: You suspect she knows what?

MARK: That her withering, frightened look, her choking sounds at night

LUKE: From the disease? She has it?

MARK: She's breathed too much of the chalk. I think she knows that soon it will be necessary to relieve myself of her presence in my place.

LUKE: I don't think you'll do that. No, you couldn't do that.

MARK: You haven't sat for an hour observing me waiting for you, and so you know me less.

LUKE: Since I know you completely

MARK: Are you sure that you do?

LUKE: I feel secure with you, Mark. And as for the woman you've never mentioned before, have you told her about us?

MARK: I say nothing to her now but, "Oh, are you still here? Go lie down in that corner over there and don't cough and don't crawl toward me."

LUKE: You're making all this up, I know it's not true.

MARK: You know so little, boy. You know dangerously little. You don't know enough to distrust.

LUKE: Oh, I distrust them all except you, Mark.

MARK: That might be a mistake. The worn-out girl at my place, she trusted me once as you do. But when I go home tonight, if she's still there-out she'll go, I'll throw the door open, and kick her living or dead body into the wind she can't stand against, that will sweep her away and bury her in white dust. No, don't trust. So. You said you bathe twice a day, before you come here to meet me and again at night, violating the water restrictions?

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LUKE: When I was very young

MARK: Younger than now?

LUKE: Little more than a child. I had a protector, my first, who was very clever, very wise, at secret, mechanical things. Did I say that right?

MARK: Perfectly. Go on.

LUKE: One day he put his ear to the earth.

MARK: In or out of the house?

LUKE: Both in and out, and he discovered that not far under the earth, running under the house, there was water, he said a stream of it, not wide, not deep, but

MARK: Ohhh...

LUKE: He was a strong man, he dug and dug down to it and built steps down with stones.

MARK: But when the house is inspected by the

LUKE: Inspectors, no. You see, the opening to the steps is covered over with an old, dry animal skin, and even if the inspectors looked under this ragged leather-you know their eyes are bad, half-blinded by the chalk-they wouldn't notice the width of the cracks.

MARK: By which you can lift the cover to the underground spring of water? -How very foolish of you!

LUKE: He did it all, not I.

MARK: But he's gone now, and you have it all to yourself, for your own private and-illegal-use. You are not at all wise.

LUKE: *(Shrugging.)* I must live, and to live I must please.

MARK: But you mustn't talk about it.

LUKE: Of course not. To no one but you.

MARK: No, not even to me, because by talking about it to me, you make me a conspirator with you, as criminal as you are.

LUKE: Oh, but you

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MARK: Would bear the same penalty you would, knowing what you've told me and not-informing.

LUKE: Whom would you

MARK: Inform? The ones you inform to. The rulers, the authorities of the regime. *(Pause.)*

LUKE: You believed that story? You didn't know that it was all made up? Just an invention, like yours about the woman and what you'll do to her tonight?

MARK: That was no invention. And neither was what you told me about the underground spring.

LUKE: You're holding me so tight it's hard to breathe.

MARK: You're a light-footed boy. You might suddenly spring up and take to your heels.

LUKE: From you?

MARK: Of course, now that you realize that you've made such a dangerous mistake. I suspected something. And now I know.

LUKE: But I know something, too.

MARK: What?

LUKE: You've told me how completely you love me.

MARK: A thing that I also told the woman when she was desirable to me.

LUKE: She doesn't still attract you. I do. Don't I? Mark?

MARK: You've put in my possession a secret that to keep from the authorities would expose me to the same penalty you're exposed to. You know what such penalties are?

LUKE: A term of imprisonment, but

MARK: A long, long term, and even if you're alive when it expires, you'd be unrecognizable, Luke.

LUKE: I'd be disfigured, you mean?

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MARK: By more than time, by more than the terminal effect of the chalky white substance. *(He clamps his arms tighter about Luke.)*

LUKE: What are you, why are you-!

MARK: I must deliver you to them and repeat your confession and receive the bounty. Did you know there's a bounty offered for turning in a person who violates the laws, the restrictions? The authorities regard him with more respect, he's given a title, sometimes, and his licenses are extended. The inspectors pay his house a-respectful visit, they smile at him and say, "The place needs some improvements in keeping with your new position. We'll see to that right away."

LUKE: The authorities are vicious.

MARK: I understand that's always been their nature, even before the people of the earth divided into two or three hostile parts that battled for ownership and rule with the great explosive devices. Who won? Nobody. *Nobody*! *(The italicized word is echoed, after a couple of moments, from the opposite side of the chasm.)* Hear that? Know what that was? As if somebody called back? That was an echo. So many of the old words have dropped out of use and aren't known anymore. *(Pause.)*

LUKE: The authorities are corrupt, but we don't have to imitate them.

MARK: To save our skins we do.

LUKE: Would they still be worth saving?

MARK: I understand that there used to be considerations called moral. And for these considerations, morality, a thing such as the betrayal of someone you love, would be held in contempt. But that was once, long before I remember. Stop struggling. I'm hard and strong. What's the use? You can't escape. Light's faded. We must get going.

LUKE: Where? The cave? Or my place?

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MARK: Neither this evening, Luke. We're going to the cabildo where you will stay confined till long out-used, to the end of your time. -Time! *(The pause; the echo.)*

LUKE: Then kill me. Kill me, Mark!

MARK: And sacrifice the reward? *(Wind rises. Luke thrashes impotently in the grasp of Mark.)* Call him, the great protector called God. No breath? I'll call Him for you. Pro-tec-tor! *(Pause; the echo.)* What a huge creature, what an immense beast He must have been to have left such enormous white bones when He died. . . End-lessly long ago, the bones of Him now turned to powder that blows and blows about His broken-creation. . . *(He bears Luke, futilely struggling, down the upstage declivity, and the stage darkens.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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